



ON THE WRITE LINE

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COOLING-OFF PERIOD IMPORTANT BEFORE MAKING RETIRED PLAYER COACH OR SELECTOR

I have been witness to how a **perceived slight** has resulted to a huge extent in a player being left out of the team, though the reason given was the shot he had played.

A few days before the Test series between Australia and Pakistan started, there was a huge uproar in Australian cricket circles, with Mitchell Johnson questioning David Warner's place in the Test team and also wondering why he should be allowed to bid goodbye to Test cricket when he wants to. His argument was that, apart from a double century last year, Warner hadn't scored enough runs in the previous few years to be guaranteed a place on the team. Warner had announced his intention of quitting Test cricket after playing at his home ground, Sydney, early next year.

Johnson was querying how Warner could consider himself a certainty for all three Test matches against Pakistan, looking at his lack of runs except for that double century. Warner has now answered that in fine style by hitting a brilliant century in the first Test match in Perth. Though he got out for a duck in the second innings, his 164 in the first innings pretty much assures him a spot in the eleven for the next two Test matches.

Johnson admitted that a text message from Warner in April had been the main driver for

his article about Warner's place in the side.

Players who have earlier been teammates falling out with each other is nothing new in sports, and that's why it's important to have a cooling-off period before a retired player is given the responsibility of coaching the team or being a selector. Some perceived slights with his former teammate may cloud judgement and lead to some ill-judged decisions against his former teammate, who is still playing. The BCCI has got it right with a five-year cooling-off period after retirement before appointing the retired player as a selector and coach, and that's how it should be.

Hopefully, by then, any lingering ill feelings will have been tempered by the passage of time.

Something similar should be done before a coach of a state or an IPL team is appointed a selector because you don't want any player suffering from bias by the state or IPL coach.

I have been witness to how a perceived slight has resulted to a huge extent in a player being left out of the team, though the reason given was the shot he had played. I was coopted with no voting rights on that selection committee because I was the captain of the team. The selector concerned was livid